

EXTENDING EXTRAORDINARY CARE THROUGH ROBOTIC SURGERIES!



government (moot question) catering to the middle and EWS sections of the society for which significant up-scaling needs to be done.

Q With AI embedded technology taking centerstage in the recent years, how has it leveraged surgical intervention outcomes and the future that you can perceive?

We will have to live with the disruptor -AI, as it is going to stay. Currently, AI is being used in radiology, pathology and diagnostics, proving to be a huge advantage. Unlike the limited human capacity to learn, go through reports and sift information to reach a conclusion, the machine can do much better in many aspects as it can learn within a day a 1000, 10000 to a million cases. Nevertheless, the output will have to be verified. Wherever there is a reading programme on a mass scale, technology can do the job much better. When it comes to procedures, for simpler case laparoscopy will serve its purpose, while robotics will be able to manage complex cases with precision, and it's going to be the future.

Q Today, which are the organs that can be harvested, and the organ most in demand for transplantation?

The waiting list is long for kidney transplants as they are the most in demand because such patients are either on dialysis or in the end stage. Fortunately, patients on dialysis can live for years. Whereas, the number of patients in queue for liver transplant is comparatively much less because they cannot survive beyond six to one year if the transplant is not done within the timeframe. Living donor and cadaver transplants are possible on kidney and liver patients. On the contrary, only cadaver transplants can be done in heart and lung cases, which are not very common in our country. Limb and uterine transplants, though few in numbers, have

been performed on patients in India.

Q You have a huge body of stellar achievements in academics, and organ transplantation, as well. What would you like to be known as- Professor Mohamed Rela or Surgeon DR. Mohamed Rela?

To keep it simple, I would like to be known as Dr Rela. The prefix of Professor came as a title given to me by King George's College Hospital, UK, for the research work that I did which entitled me to a personal Chair, so that's how the title of professor got tagged to my professional credentials.

Q What inspired you to specialize in liver transplantation, and the challenges that you faced as a surgeon in the early days of practice?

When I started liver transplant in 1991, it was a fledgling specialty. I had moved to London at a time when not many British doctors in the UK, wanted to do liver transplant for its notoriety of being a very difficult specialty entailing duty calls at unconventional hours for unscheduled emergency operations. That gap came as an opportunity for me to get into a new field. Liver surgery by itself is one of the most complex surgical fields, a challenge that I took up and found myself to be good at. That's how I started my career and successfully completed more than 35 years in the specialty.

Q You have pioneered innovation in liver transplantation techniques, the skills have also won you a place of privilege in the Guinness World of Records. Could you elaborate on this landmark moment in your life?

In those early days of the specialty, unfortunately most infants succumbed to liver failure resulting in poor outcomes. It was my keen interest in doing liver transplants on infants that motivated me and the

team at the King George Hospital, UK, where at their specialized liver paediatric department, we developed a technique of doing safe transplants on newly born babies. It so happened that an Irish couple lost their child to liver failure due to congenital disorder. They were aware that their next child to be born would also meet a similar fate as the earlier new born. As soon as their baby was born they recognized that the child had the same conditions like the previous child. We planned the operation and performed it when the child was just five days into this world, an unbeaten record till date. I was unaware nor did I think that such an operation was conducted for the first time in the world. One of my colleague wrote to the Guinness Book of World Record informing them of the feat and before long I was mentioned in the annals of their book. Today, that infant girl child is a healthy young woman of 24 and a joy to behold.

Q If you were to dream of living another life what would it be?

I believe, God blesses everyone with some ability, and that they should be able to identify, recognize and excel by working towards that chosen direction. When young, I was passionate about becoming a surgeon, and fortunately I went on to become an able surgeon. I believe that the liver is an unique organ, involving high-end surgery and I have been able to excel in that. God has guided me in the right direction and I have chosen to do the right thing for me. I feel happy and extremely privileged to be doing what I am doing. Apart from the tangible worldly achievements, the most important aspect of my chosen career path provides an opportunity to serve people, save lives. My parents placed utmost importance on educating me and my siblings. My mother, who has seen my progress throughout stays with me, and I continue to get her blessings.